USC Marshall
School of Business
Graduate Career Services

Networking and Informational Interview Questions

These guidelines have been prepared for all USC Marshall Graduate students.

Successful informational interviewing starts by asking appropriate questions at each stage in the development of a new professional relationship. Questions for a recent graduate or young alumnus/a will differ from those for a C-suite or experienced professional. Plan your list of questions based on your research, as well as the level of rapport in your current networking relationship.

A Few Tips Before Starting:

- Be specific in what you are asking for (a phone call, a chat over coffee), for how long (20 minutes, 45 minutes), when (next week, in two weeks), and that you will follow up. Include your email and phone number, even when using LinkedIn.
- Confirm the appointment the day before through email or a phone call.
- Dress appropriately, and arrive 10-15 minutes early. First impressions matter: a professional handshake, a smile.
- Be informed: research the company and the function. Know the industry, its recent challenges and significant events, and a little background on your networking contact.
- Print out the list of questions you will ask. Be an active listener to the responses; create a rich and rewarding conversation.
- Respect the timeframe: don't exceed what you requested (20 minutes, 30 minutes) unless the contact indicates otherwise.
- Ask what you can do for the contact. Never ask for a job. Always send a thank you note within 48 hours of your meeting.

The Networking Contact:

Topics: Work history, personal impressions or opinions, decision-making process, career planning, hindsight.

- What attracted you to this job (company, industry)? What do you enjoy most about your job (company, industry)?
- Tell me about the career path that led you to your job. What made you decide to work for this firm?
- What do you think has made you successful throughout your career?
- What do you find unique about your career field?
- What are possible next steps for you? What career expectations do you have in the short/ long term?
- What do you wish you'd known before you entered this field? What classes did you wish you had taken in business school?
- What keeps you motivated in the organization?
- What are you most excited/concerned about for this industry/company/career path in the future?
- What is your "stress buster"? What do you do with your free time?

The Job:

Topics: Role and responsibilities, challenges, expectations, skills, projects, successful characteristics of candidates.

- What does your typical day look like? Week? Month? Year? Do you have a set routine?
- What are the key skills someone needs to develop in order to be successful in your position or industry?
- Which experiences enabled you to develop these skills? How do you keep skills current?
- What are some ways that other people you know have gotten their start in this field?
- What's the most challenging projects that you have worked on? Would you describe your most recent project/assignment?
- What projects have you worked on that were particularly interesting?
- What new products or services have you launched?
- What do you do if you cannot solve a problem on your own?
- What journals (magazines, blogs, etc.) do you read? What professional associations do you belong to? What seminars or continuing education do you consider useful?
- Where do you and your supervisor fit into the organizational structure? How are teams structured?
- What are the common misconceptions about working in this field? What was your biggest surprise about this field?
- How much flexibility do you have in determining how you perform your job?
- Are there other responsibilities you are expected to pursue outside work hours?
- To what extent does this job present a challenge in terms of juggling work and family life?
- What has been your biggest challenge in the last three months? (Research the issue and then respond: send or recommend an article, event, book, etc., you discovered based on your conversation.)

The Company:

Topics: Products/services, culture, training, cross-team/dept. collaboration, mission, management.

- What does the culture look like? (Turnover, management style, conservative/liberal, office attire, out of office activities)
- What's something about your company that can't be read about online?
- What is the philosophy of the company or organization? (Is it a people-, service-, or product-oriented business?)
- Based on my research about the firm, I found (describe in brief a topic). What are your thoughts on this issue?
- What are the strong areas/practices for this firm and which areas and practices does the office specialize in?
- I recently read online/saw on television _____ about your company. What are your thoughts / strategies / views?
- Could you give some examples of teamwork and the support you get from your peers/superiors at the firm on projects?
- What does the company do to foster innovation and creativity?
- What are some defining characteristics of the candidates who have been hired in the past for this position?
- What systems are in place to enable employees to give management feedback and suggestions?
- What are the opportunities for personal development/ continuing education at the firm? Is there a mentorship program?
- What kind of training program does the company offer? Is it highly structured or more informal?
- Is the company's management style top-down, or do front-line employees share in decision-making?
- How does the company recognize outstanding accomplishments of its employees?
- How does the company make use of technology for internal communication and outside marketing? (Use of e-mail, Internet, Intranet, videoconferencing, etc.)?

The Industry:

Topics: Current issues/upcoming challenges (political, economic, social) based on current research, competition, recent innovations, future outlook.

- Why did you choose this company rather than a competitor?
- What do you like most about working in this industry?
- What do you see as the biggest competitive challenge for your company?
- What major factors will effect this industry in the next year (five years, ten years)?
- How will your company deal with issues surrounding _____ that could potentially effect the industry?
- What differentiates your company from its competitors that isn't readily apparent?

Final Questions / Your Goals:

Topics: Additional connections, advice, resources, professional associations, career advice, methods to close the gaps.

- Is there anything I can do to help you right now?
- My background is in _____. How do you think I can best leverage my previous experience?
- What should I focus on at business school to make me more attractive as a potential candidate for your company?
- Can you recommend an event/ an online resource / a professional association that can provide additional information?
- I've identified my gaps as _____. I plan to close them by _____. Do you agree and can you suggest other methods to help close those gaps?
- Would you recommend a colleague / manager / director in the company to speak to next?
- Would you recommend a couple more people to speak with to learn more about (a specific topic or area of interest)?
- I've already spoken to Name, Name and Name. Which Marshall alumni do you consider to be exceptional in this function (company, industry)? May I reach out to them as potential networking contacts as well?
- If I have questions in the future, could I set up another call (meeting, quick coffee) with you?

Questions to Avoid:

Topics: Too personal, outside of the contact's scope, salary information, a job, a reference.

- What's your salary? What is compensation like? (Avoid salary/compensation unless the contact indicates otherwise.)
- How often do you have to travel (especially for consulting)?
- Are there any openings? Can you recommend me for the role?
- Asking questions too complex or too broad about strategic direction, growth, etc., especially for junior level professionals.
- Questions where the answer can be researched easily: i.e., What does your company do?
- Anything about relationships, race, politics, religion, etc.
- Questions about insider or confidential information.